

NOT ONE MAN'S FOLLY

Both India and Pakistan must admit that leaders on both sides had erred

By MARK TULLY

The biblical saying, a prophet is not without honour except in his own country, has been turned on its head in India. The row over who was responsible for Partition, sparked off by Jaswant Singh's biography of Jinnah, has shown that Nehru is honoured too much in his own country. The Congress spokesman, reacting to Jaswant's book and his interview with Karan Thapar, said, "He (Jaswant) and his party have further proved their patriotism by denigrating India's first Prime Minister while eulogising Pakistan's first head of state." In the Congress's view, any criticism of Nehru is denigration, and any praise of Jinnah is eulogy, a classic case of seeing something in black and white. But when neighbours anywhere see their disputes in black and white, they leave no room for compromise, and compromise is essential if good relations are to be restored.

With its stand, the Congress has revived the bitterness of Partition. The Congress has also incidentally played into the hands of BJP hardliners by supporting their point of view. Ironically, Nehru himself was prepared to admit he might have made mistakes

which helped to partition India. Jaswant quotes a letter Nehru wrote to the Nawab of Bhopal on July 9, 1948 in which he says, "I know that we are to blame for many matters... Partition came and we accepted it because we thought that perhaps that way, however painful it was, we might have some peace... Perhaps we acted wrongly."

The Pavlovian responses of the Congress and indeed the BJP cannot but add to the difficulty of ever achieving what Nehru himself wanted. In that letter to the Nawab of Bhopal, he also said that there was no other way to peace, except for India or Pakistan to come close together. He envisaged "some kind of federal link". Furthermore, the two national parties' refusal to acknowledge that Jinnah did, ultimately at least, advocate a secular Pakistan only weakens the case for better relations with India in that country. I can't see how it's possible not to interpret Jinnah's presidential address to the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan as stating that it was his intention Pakistan

should be secular. What else can these words mean, "You may belong to any religion or caste or creed that has nothing to do with the business of the State."

At the launch of Jaswant's book, Hameed Haroon, the CEO of Dawn, a major Pakistani media group, regretted that the image of a secular Jinnah had not been portrayed in Pakistan. He said, "Jinnah's pictures wearing Western dress and smoking cigarettes were suppressed in Pakistan, and he became a two-dimensional cardboard representation of Zia's ideals." Would it not be much better for Indian politicians to hope that Jaswant's book might revive the secular image of Jinnah in Pakistan? That would surely strengthen the hands of the many Pakistanis who like Haroon want to

see the realisation of Jinnah's vision of relations between the two countries. In a statement he made just before he left Delhi for Karachi at the time of Independence, he said, "The past must be buried and let us start afresh as two independent sovereign states of Hindustan and Pakistan."

I am not a historian, so I can't comment on the more arcane disputes about who was responsible for Partition.

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I can say that, in spite of the BJP and Congress's reactions, Jaswant's book is not a whitewash job. The Jinnah who emerges is far from faultless. For instance, Jaswant writes, "Jinnah was to my mind fundamentally in error proposing Muslims as a separate nation." Everyone comes in for blame in the book, Gandhi, Nehru, Jinnah, and the British. It's only when both sides in a dispute are prepared to admit that right is not entirely on their side that the past can be buried. It is being buried in Northern Ireland. It is being buried in America, The election of Barack Obama is a giant step towards burying America's racial past. Sadly, the reaction to Jaswant's book indicates that India is still not ready for the interment of its past. The way to leave Partition behind is for all those who wish for a fresh start to relations between India and Pakistan to admit that mistakes were made by the leaders on both sides and of course by the British.

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